



Module 5: After the Flood

SESSIONS 20-22

Unpack the final scenes of the flood story, and consider how the flood story shows up in modern conversations.

Session 20: God's Covenant With Noah

Key Takeaways

- God prohibits consuming blood to remind people that all life ultimately belongs to God.
- A covenant is an external mechanism used to bind together a relationship that has been broken.

God Provides Food and Prohibits Bloodshed: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:1-7

¹ And Elohim blessed Noah and his sons
and he said to them,
“Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the land .

a ² The fear of you and the terror of you will be
b upon every living creature of the land
and upon every bird of the skies;
with everything that creeps on the ground,
and with all the fish of the sea;
a' into your hand they are given ;
b ³ every creeper that is living ,
for you it will be for eating ,
a' I give all to you , as I gave the green plant.

a ⁴ Only the flesh with its life , its blood , you will not eat ;
⁵ indeed, I will require your life-blood ;
b from every beast I will require it,
b' and from every human,
from a man's brother,
b'' I will require the life of a human.
a' ⁶ He who pours out the blood of a human,
by a human will his blood be poured out,
because in the image of God he made humanity.

⁷ And as for you all, be fruitful and multiply ;

Genesis 9:1-7. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Structural Links Between 9:1-7, 6:21, and 1:29-30

Just as God instructed Noah to prepare food for himself and the animals as they boarded the ark (in 6:21), so now God instructs Noah on the provision of food outside the ark. But notice that God's words explicitly reference his command to all humanity in Genesis 1:29-30 and indicate a new program in light of humanity's violent nature that has been revealed in the flood narrative.

Genesis 9:2-3 Instructor's Translation

² Every living creature of the land and upon every bird of the skies; with everything that creeps on the ground, and with all the fish of the sea; into your hand they are given; ³ every creeper that's living, for you it will be for food (לכם יהיה לאכלה), I give all to you, as I gave the green plant (כירק עשב נתתי).

Animals are given as food for the humans, just as the green plants were.

Genesis 6:21 Instructor's Translation

And as for you, take for yourself some of all edible-food that you will eat, and gather it to yourself; and it shall be for food for you (לך לאכלה) and for them.

Genesis 1:29-30 Instructor's Translation

²⁹ Then God said, "Behold, I have given you every plant (נתתי לכם כל עשב) yielding seed that is on the surface of all the earth, and every tree which has fruit yielding seed; to you it shall be food (לכם יהיה לאכלה) ³⁰and to every beast of the earth and to every bird of the sky and to every creature that moved on the earth which has life-being in it, every green plant for food." And it was so.

Green plants are given as food for humans and for the animals.

9:1-6 develops the themes of 1:26-30 in light of what the flood story argues about human nature. When human nature was pre-violence, a plant-based diet was the ideal. But now that humans take life, God regulates this new situation with guidelines that express the same ethical principles later found in the laws of Mount Sinai.

Genesis 1:27-30; Leviticus 17; Genesis 4

Genesis 1:28a: And God blessed them and said, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land"

Genesis 9:1-6

¹ And God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land."

Restrictions on the Blood of Animals. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Genesis 1:27-30; Leviticus 17; Genesis 4	Genesis 9:1-6
Genesis 1:28b: "and subdue it and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the skies and over every living creatures that creeps on the land."	2a "And the fear of you and the terror of you will be upon all the beast of the land and over all the birds of the skies, over all that creeps the ground and over all the fish of the sea."
Genesis 1:29-30: Then God said, "Behold, I have given you every plant (כל עשב ... נתתי לכם) yielding seed that is on the surface of all the earth, and every tree which has fruit yielding seed; to you it shall be food (לכם יהיה לאכלה) and to every beast of the earth and to every bird of the sky and to every thing that moves on the earth which has life-being in it, every green plant for food"; and it was so.	2b-3 "Into your hands they are given (בידכם נתנו). Every creeping thing, which has life, to you it will be for food (לכם יהיה לאכלה), just as I gave to you the green plant (כירק עשב נתתי לכם)."
Lev 17:11-13: "For the life of flesh is in its blood , and I have given it to you (נתתי לכם) upon the altar to atone (לכפר על נפשתיכם) for your lives, for the blood that is in the life atones. Therefore I said ... ' No living being among you shall eat the blood. '" Genesis 3 "you shall not eat"	4 "Surely you shall not eat flesh with its life, its blood. "
Genesis 4:8: Cain murders " his brother " (אחיו) Genesis 4:23: Lemek murders " a man " (איש)	5 "Surely ... I will require your blood which is your life from every beast I will require it and from the hand of a man (איש), his brother (אחיו), I will require the life of human.
Genesis 1:27: God created human in his own image, in the image of God he created him ; male and female he created them.	6 Whoever sheds human blood, by human his blood shall be shed, for in the image of God he made human.
<i>Restrictions on the Blood of Animals.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Humanity's rule over the animals in Eden was conducted in the context of peaceful relations with them (Gen. 2:18-20). Now in the post-flood reality, a violent and bloodthirsty humanity rules the animals. The animals will see such humans as a source of fear and threat, and so human rule over them will be an exercise of fear (Gen. 9:2a).

Links in Genesis 9:2-3

This threatening human rule over the animals is related to the fact that humans want to eat the animals, and so God grants this as a concession. This is presented here in comparison to and as a lessening of the vegan garden ideal of Genesis 1:29-30.

"In [Genesis 1] creation account, only a vegetarian diet is mentioned either for humans or animals (Gen. 1:29-30). In the paradise story the first human's relationship to the animals certainly expresses authority, but the question is of companionship, not of eating them (Gen. 2:19). After the flood, the situation has changed. Noah offers animals and birds in sacrifice (Gen. 8:20). In Genesis 9:2-7, God reaffirms the grant of sovereignty over animals and birds, but from now on they are to be under the 'fear and dread' of humankind. As God originally gave all plants to humans for food, now he gives them all that moves, subject only to the prohibition of eating blood ... The effect of this passage immediately preceding the formal promise of God's covenant with both humans and animals is that mutual relationships between creatures of the earth are now envisaged as they are, not as they were idealized in Genesis 1 and 2, or in any other vision of universal peace. The Bible contains, in fact, two models for thinking about humans and animals: one paradisaical, the other this-worldly and realistic. The first way uses the picture of peace with and between wild animals (Isaiah 11) as a metaphor for cosmic and social peace; the second way sees peace from them as a practical aspect of desired shalom."

Murray, Robert (2007). [*The Cosmic Covenant: Biblical Themes of Justice, Peace and the Integrity of Creation*](#). Gorgias Press. 34.

Links in Genesis 9:4

However, as soon as this concession is granted, God qualifies it. Taking the life of another creature does not mean humans are God. While humans may borrow the flesh of an animal for sustenance, they do not own the animal or its life. Thus, the life blood is not to be eaten. The concession to eat animals is marked by this prohibition of eating blood, which links forward to another concession: animal sacrifice in [Leviticus 17:11-13](#).

"It might be thought that the eating of blood would be so naturally repulsive as not to require legal proscription, but the history of the subject discredits such a notion. The frequency with which the prohibition is repeated in the Torah legislation testifies to the attractiveness of the practice in ancient times. Its appeal lay in the premise, explicated in Leviticus 17:11, 14 and [Deuteronomy 12:23](#), that the blood constituted the life-essence. Consequently, popular thought had it that one could renew or reinforce one's vitality through its absorption of blood. For this reason, blood played an important role in the cults of the dead in the ancient world. In the Torah, however, precisely because blood is the symbol of life, it belongs to God alone, as does life itself."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 61.

Links in Genesis 9:5-6

This prohibition leads to a wider reflection on the nature of life: All life, animal and human, belongs to God, and so humans are responsible to God for how they treat life. Animal life and human life must be honored as sacred because God is their source.